

“The Goblin Market” as a feminist text

Christina Rossetti's "Goblin Market," first published in 1862, is a richly layered poem that has sparked a wide range of interpretations. Among these, the feminist reading stands out for its exploration of themes such as female agency, sisterhood, and the critique of Victorian gender norms. This tutorial paper aims to analyse "Goblin Market" as a feminist text, examining how Rossetti challenges the traditional roles and expectations of women in the 19th century. Through a close reading of the poem's narrative structure, character dynamics, and symbolic elements, we will uncover the ways in which "Goblin Market" advocates for female solidarity and empowerment.

"Goblin Market" follows the story of two sisters, Laura and Lizzie, who encounter goblin men selling exotic fruits. Laura succumbs to the temptation and consumes the fruit, resulting in a life-threatening decline. Lizzie, determined to save her sister, bravely confronts the goblin men and endures their abuse to obtain the antidote, which she selflessly shares with Laura, leading to her recovery.

This narrative structure underscores key feminist themes: Female Agency: The poem highlights the agency of women in their ability to make choices and take action. Laura's initial decision to eat the goblin fruit and Lizzie's courageous confrontation of the goblins are acts of agency, despite the different consequences each face. Their actions reflect the complexities of autonomy and resistance within a patriarchal context. Sisterhood and Solidarity: Central to the poem is the theme of sisterhood. Lizzie's unwavering determination to save Laura exemplifies the strength and importance of female solidarity. This bond between the sisters serves as a powerful counterpoint to the destructive forces represented by the goblin men. Critique of Victorian Gender Norms: "Goblin Market" critiques the Victorian ideal of women as passive and submissive. By portraying Lizzie as a resilient and proactive

heroine, Rossetti challenges the notion that women should conform to restrictive gender roles.

Laura: Laura's character represents the consequences of succumbing to temptation and the societal pressures placed on women. Her initial curiosity and subsequent consumption of the goblin fruit can be seen as a metaphor for sexual transgression or the pursuit of forbidden knowledge. Laura's fall and redemption illustrate the potential for women to regain their agency and autonomy, even after experiencing societal judgment and ostracism.

Lizzie: Lizzie embodies the ideal of female strength and resilience. Her willingness to endure physical and emotional abuse to save her sister highlights the themes of sacrifice and protective love. Lizzie's character challenges the passive role assigned to women, showcasing a model of active resistance and moral courage. Her actions emphasize the transformative power of sisterhood and mutual support.

Rossetti employs rich symbolism and vivid imagery to convey feminist themes throughout "Goblin Market." Some of the key symbols include: Goblin Men: The goblin men represent patriarchal forces that seek to exploit and subjugate women. Their seductive calls and deceptive appearances reflect the dangers women face in a male-dominated society. The goblins' violence against Lizzie when she resists them underscores the aggressive tactics used to maintain control over women. Goblin Fruit: The exotic fruits symbolize the forbidden desires and temptations that women are often warned against. The fruits' alluring appearance and detrimental effects on Laura highlight the double standard of sexual morality imposed on women. The consumption of the fruit and its consequences serve as a critique of the harsh punishments meted out to women who deviate from societal expectations.

Several feminist scholars have analysed "Goblin Market" through different lenses, offering diverse interpretations that highlight the poem's complexity. Sexual Politics: Some readings of "Goblin Market" focus on the sexual undertones of the goblin fruit and the sisters' interactions with the goblin men. These interpretations suggest that the poem addresses the sexual exploitation and commodification of women. Laura's consumption of the fruit and her subsequent decline can be read as a commentary on the dangers of succumbing to male desire and the loss of female autonomy. Economic Independence: Another feminist interpretation considers the economic implications of the poem. The goblin market can be seen as a metaphor for the marketplace and the limited economic opportunities available to women in Victorian society. Laura and Lizzie's need to engage with the goblin men highlights the dependence of women on men for economic survival. Lizzie's act of resistance, therefore, can be interpreted as a call for economic independence and self-sufficiency. Religious Allegory: Some scholars view "Goblin Market" as a religious allegory with feminist undertones. Lizzie's self-sacrifice and redemptive role align with Christ-like imagery, presenting her as a saviour figure. This reading suggests that Rossetti, who had strong religious beliefs, used the poem to explore themes of redemption and spiritual salvation, while simultaneously advocating for the empowerment of women through religious and moral integrity.

"Goblin Market" remains relevant today as it continues to resonate with contemporary feminist issues. The poem's exploration of female agency, solidarity, and resistance against patriarchal forces parallels ongoing struggles for gender equality and women's rights. Body Autonomy and Consent: The themes of bodily autonomy and consent in "Goblin Market" are particularly pertinent in discussions of modern feminist movements. Laura's consumption of the goblin fruit and Lizzie's resistance to the goblin men highlight the importance of respecting women's choices and bodily autonomy. These themes align with contemporary advocacy for women's rights to control their own bodies and make autonomous decision.

Challenging Gender Norms: "Goblin Market" challenges traditional gender norms and roles, a theme that continues to be relevant as society grapples with issues of gender identity and expression. By presenting Lizzie as a proactive and courageous heroine, Rossetti disrupts the passive female archetype and offers an alternative model of femininity that is assertive and empowered.

Christina Rossetti's "Goblin Market" is a multifaceted poem that lends itself to a rich feminist interpretation. Through its narrative structure, character dynamics, and symbolic elements, the poem explores themes of female agency, sisterhood, and resistance against patriarchal oppression. Rossetti's portrayal of Laura and Lizzie challenges Victorian gender norms and advocates for the empowerment and solidarity of women. The poem's enduring relevance underscores its significance as a feminist text that continues to inspire and resonate with contemporary audiences.

Works Cited List

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